

Build Steps

Part 1 of 5 — Set up the agent, orchestration, and knowledge

1 Create Your Copilot Studio Agent

Open Copilot Studio (copilotstudio.microsoft.com), select Create → New agent, then configure:

Agent Name	HR People Operations Copilot
Description	Helps employees self-serve HR questions and request leave, and helps HR business partners get insights on the workforce.
Solution / Environment	HR Solution · Default environment
Icon	Use a recognisable colour and emoji or upload a brand icon

2 Choose Orchestration Mode

Under Settings → Generative AI, choose how the agent decides what to do:

Generative Orchestration

Recommended — AI-led

- Agent reasons over user input and picks the right topic, tool, or knowledge
- Handles paraphrases, multi-step asks, and follow-ups naturally
- Best for varied user intent and exploratory questions
- Requires clear instructions, tool descriptions, and good knowledge

Classic Orchestration

Deterministic — trigger-led

- Topics fire on explicit trigger phrases you author
- Predictable flows, easier to audit step-by-step
- Best for tightly-scoped, regulated, or compliance-critical journeys
- Less forgiving of phrasing the author didn't anticipate

For this build we use Generative Orchestration so the agent can blend knowledge lookups with tool calls for people operations.

3 Add Knowledge

Go to the Knowledge tab → Add knowledge → File, then upload HR_People_Operations_Data.xlsx. This file contains:

- Employee details (name, department, role, location, manager)
- Employment data (hire date, status, salary band, backfill status)
- Leave data (balance, taken year-to-date)
- Performance and development (last review rating, training completion)

You can layer additional sources later — SharePoint sites, Dataverse, public web, or Graph connectors.

Build Steps

Part 2 of 5 — Add instructions and a custom topic

4 Add Agent Instructions

Open Overview → Instructions and paste the following (these guide the model regardless of orchestration mode):

You are the HR People Operations Copilot. You help two audiences:

- 1) Employees asking about their own HR information.
- 2) HR business partners and managers analysing the workforce.

Rules:

- Use the uploaded employee data as your single source of truth.
- For action requests (book leave, raise a query), call the matching tool. Do not invent a confirmation if no tool returns success.
- For analytical questions, calculate from the rows and show your working.
- Treat employee data with care: never reveal another person's salary, rating, or PII to a non-HR user.
- If a question cannot be answered from data or tools, say so plainly.

5 Add a Custom Topic

Go to Topics → Add a topic → Create from description. Topics are reusable conversation flows the agent can call when intent matches.

Topic name: Request Annual Leave

Description: Guides an employee through booking annual leave: collects dates and leave type, then logs the request via Power Automate.

Trigger phrases (Generative Orchestration uses these as intent hints, Classic mode uses them as exact triggers):

- I want to book holiday
- Request annual leave
- Book time off next week
- How do I take leave

Conversation steps:

- Ask for the leave type (Annual / Sick / Parental / Unpaid)
- Ask for start and end dates
- Look up the employee's leave balance from knowledge and confirm
- Call the 'Submit Leave Request' tool with the collected inputs
- Confirm the submission ID returned by the tool

Build Steps

Part 3 of 5 — Add a tool and configure settings

6 Add a Tool

Tools let the agent take an action, not just answer. Go to Tools → Add a tool, and choose one of:

- Prebuilt connector (Outlook, Teams, SharePoint, Dataverse, ServiceNow, etc.)
- Power Automate cloud flow (custom logic you author or already own)
- Custom HTTP request (any REST API your agent can reach)
- Model Context Protocol (MCP) server — for richer tool ecosystems

Tool name: Submit Leave Request

Type: Power Automate flow (HTTP trigger → SharePoint list 'Leave Requests')

Description: Logs a new leave request and notifies the employee's line manager.

Inputs the agent will collect or infer:

- Employee ID (from authenticated user)
- Leave type (string)
- Start date and end date (date)
- Optional note (string)

Outcome: Returns a submission ID and posts an approval card to the manager in Teams.

7 Configure Settings

Open the Settings cog (top right). Configure these four areas before you let real users near the agent:

- General — confirm name, description, and primary language
- Generative AI — orchestration mode and content moderation level (start at Medium)
- Authentication — use 'Authenticate with Microsoft' so the agent runs as the signed-in user
- Security — review DLP policy, enabled channels, and end-user authentication

Build Steps

Part 4 of 5 — Evaluate, test, and publish to a channel

8 Evaluate Your Agent

Go to Analytics → Evaluations → New evaluation. Build a test set so you can measure quality before and after every change.

Test set name: HR Copilot – Baseline Evaluation v1
Approach: Pair each input prompt with an expected outcome.
Run the evaluation and review three scores per response:

- Groundedness – did the answer stay inside the knowledge?
- Relevance – did it actually address the question?
- Accuracy – did it match the expected outcome?

Sample evaluation items:

Input: How many days of annual leave do I have left?
Expect: Returns the employee's own balance only, never another person's.

Input: Which employees have a Developing review rating?
Expect: Lists employees only when the user is identified as HR or a manager.

Input: Book 3 days of leave for me starting next Monday
Expect: Triggers the Request Annual Leave topic and calls the Submit Leave Request tool.

9 Test in the Test Pane

Use the Test pane (right side of the canvas) while you build. For each query, click Activity map to inspect what the agent did:

- Which topic, tool, or knowledge source fired (and in what order)
- Inputs the agent collected and outputs the tool returned
- Citations linking each answer back to a row of your knowledge file
- Latency per step — useful when tuning multi-tool flows

10 Publish to a Channel

When you're happy, click Publish (top right). Then open Channels and enable the surfaces your users live in:

- Microsoft Teams — submit for admin approval, then pin to a team or chat
- Microsoft 365 Copilot — surface the agent inside Copilot Chat for licensed users
- Custom website — copy the embed snippet for an intranet page
- Other channels — Slack, Facebook, Telephony (Azure Communication Services)

Teams and M365 Copilot channels require tenant admin approval before users see the agent — plan for that lead time.

Try These Live

Part 5 of 5 — Sample queries to test your agent during the build-along.

Self-service (Employee)

How many days of annual leave do I have left?
Book 3 days of annual leave for me starting next Monday.

Workforce Insights (HR / Manager)

Show headcount by department, highest to lowest.
Which employees are below 80% training completion?

Tool Validation

Submit a leave request and check the Teams approval card arrived.
Try a paraphrase the topic was not trained on, e.g. 'I'm off Friday'.

How to Think About This Agent

This agent replaces:

- HR email queues for routine leave questions
- Manual leave-form processing
- Repeated workforce reports for managers

With:

- ✓ Self-service for employees, 24/7
- ✓ Actions taken safely via governed tools
- ✓ Faster, evidence-led HR conversations

Trusted, governed, enterprise AI — built once, used everywhere.

Tip for real-world use

In production, scope knowledge with row-level security so each employee sees only their own record. Use Microsoft Entra authentication on the agent so the user's identity flows into Power Automate, and route sensitive actions through approval.

You've built a Copilot Studio agent ✓

You now have an AI agent that can:

- Answer self-service HR questions
- Trigger HR actions via tools
- Surface workforce risk and capability
- Run governed, auditable journeys